

Winning, losing and beyond it

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The FIFAe World Cup brings the best esports teams from around the globe together, and India is becoming a consistent presence in the tournament.

Daniel 'DaNiAL' Patel (in pic) reached the semifinals of the 2024 World Cup and, two years later, helped India secure a spot in the 2026 edition. Playing alongside Mujtaba 'MujjiCool' Husaini for Team India, he won the inaugural FIFAe Continental Championship Asia to guarantee a World Cup spot in FIFAe Mobile.

The eTigers won thrice in the group stages, including in matches against Myanmar and Uzbekistan. The duo's biggest challenges were Thailand — a higher-ranked opponent — and Japan, which had beaten India in the regional online qualifiers for the 2025 World Cup.

But DaNiAL and MujjiCool looked in form, and they beat the Thais twice in a row, including in the semifinal. Thailand fell five spots, and India rose by as many, breaking into the top 10

of FIFAe Mobile rankings. A 1-0 win on aggregate over Japan in the final meant some scores had been settled, and India was the continental champion.

"We're feeling so proud about what we've done. All our fans sitting at home are also part of this. It feels incredible. We worked really hard for this, and we brought home the trophy. I'm proud of my partner Danial. He's been superb throughout the tournament," Husaini said.

The FIFAe World Cup 2026 will also mark the return of a major esports tournament to Saudi Arabia. Riyadh has emerged as one of the nerve centres of esports in recent years, hosting two Esports World Cups. But with regional tensions forcing the EWC to move to Paris and the Esports Nations Cup to be postponed to 2027, Saudi Arabia's next major esports event will be the FIFAe World Cup in Jeddah, from October 16 to 25.

A helping hand

Sports, including esports, are primarily about winning, losing and

the drama around it. But when the curtains come down, what more does it offer?

In the last week of August, a series of flash floods ravaged areas of Nepal and the Tibet-China border, affecting millions of people in and around the area. At the time of writing, Nepal's death toll stands at 1355, while nearly 5000 people are still missing.

Over the next few days, the world came together to lend a helping hand, including the esports community. S8UL Esports' Gulrez Khan, known as Joker Ki Haveli, hosted a charity livestream with fellow creators and gamers, raising NPR 7.71 lakh.

With over four million followers and subscribers across YouTube and Instagram, Gulrez then extended his efforts to Assam, where he travelled to flood-affected villages, including Simaluguri, Polokhoni (Banmukh) and Bamunpukhuri (Gogainbari), to ground-manage efforts.

So, what does sport really offer? Hope when everything else lacks it.